KEN DALA

PHOTO / ALMATY MOUNTAINS / FULL BLEED COVER

THE TRAVEL JOURNAL / ISSUE 02

KAZAKHSTAN

Where the steppe meets the mountains.

CURATED BY KEN DALA

THE ESSENTIAL GUIDE

A note from Ken Dala

An invitation to explore Kazakhstan beyond the expected.

INSIDER NOTES

Kazakhstan is a country of extraordinary scale: alpine lakes, immense grasslands, futuristic architecture, ancient Silk Road cities and a living nomadic heritage. This journal is designed to help you find your own rhythm, from mountain mornings to evenings around a welcoming table. Explore thoughtfully, travel at a comfortable pace and leave space for discovery.

KEN DALA TIP

The most memorable journeys balance celebrated sights with quiet local encounters.

KEN DALA

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PHOTO / KAZAKHSTAN LANDSCAPE PANORAMA

A land of contrasts

An introduction to Kazakhstan, from city skylines to open steppe.

Find your Kazakhstan

A destination for every kind of traveler.

PHOTO / KAZAKHSTAN LANDSCAPE COLLAGE

THE EXPERIENCE

City lovers find design, museums and lively cafés in Almaty and Astana. Nature seekers discover the Tian Shan, Charyn Canyon and remarkable alpine lakes. History enthusiasts trace the Silk Road through Turkistan and Otrar, while adventurous travelers venture toward the Altai or the remote landscapes of Mangystau.

Choose two nearby regions rather than trying to see the entire country.

THE ESSENTIAL GUIDE

When to visit

A seasonal guide for a vast country.

INSIDER NOTES

Spring (April–May) brings blossoms and mild city weather, though mountain trails may still be snowy. Summer (June–August) suits alpine lakes and high-altitude exploration, with heat in southern and western regions. Autumn (September–October) offers golden foliage and comfortable city sightseeing. Winter (November–March) brings cold temperatures, snow sports and dramatic frozen landscapes.

KEN DALA TIP

Conditions vary sharply by altitude and region; check roads, trails and forecasts before departure.

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PHOTO / ALMATY CITY AND TRANS ILI ALATAU

Almaty

A mountain-framed city with an effortless cultural rhythm.

The city beneath the peaks

Parks, markets and creative neighborhoods.

PHOTO / ALMATY ASCENSION CATHEDRAL

THE EXPERIENCE

Begin with the leafy streets of central Almaty. Explore Panfilov Park and the Ascension Cathedral, browse the Green Bazaar and visit the Central State Museum or local galleries. Coffee shops, restaurants and mountain views make the city an ideal base for a few relaxed days.

Traffic can be heavy; group nearby attractions and leave time for cafés.

PLACES & PERSPECTIVES

A city of mountain views

The Tian Shan shapes the city skyline.

PHOTO / ALMATY KOK TOBE PANORAMA / WIDE

PHOTO / ALMATY KOK TOBE PANORAMA / DETAIL

PHOTO / ALMATY KOK TOBE PANORAMA / ATMOSPHERE

Medeu & Shymbulak

From mountain ice to high-altitude scenery.

PHOTO / SHYMBULAK MOUNTAIN RESORT

THE EXPERIENCE

A short journey from Almaty leads toward Medeu, known for its high-altitude skating complex, and Shymbulak, a mountain resort with lifts and sweeping views. Activities depend on the season, from skiing and snowboarding to scenic excursions and walks.

Confirm lift schedules, weather and operating status before setting out.

PLACES & PERSPECTIVES

Big Almaty Lake

A turquoise reservoir in a mountain amphitheater.

PHOTO / BIG ALMATY LAKE / WIDE

PHOTO / BIG ALMATY LAKE / DETAIL

PHOTO / BIG ALMATY LAKE / ATMOSPHERE

THE ESSENTIAL GUIDE

48 hours in Almaty

A considered first-time itinerary.

INSIDER NOTES

Day one: visit Panfilov Park and the Ascension Cathedral, browse the Green Bazaar, enjoy a traditional lunch and discover Almaty’s dining scene. Day two: head toward Medeu and Shymbulak for mountain views, weather permitting, then return for a relaxed evening. Add an extra day for museums, galleries or a guided nature excursion.

KEN DALA TIP

Big Almaty Lake access and road restrictions can change; verify current rules before visiting.

PHOTO / ASTANA BAYTEREK SKYLINE

Astana

Contemporary architecture rising from the northern steppe.

A capital of bold design

Monuments, museums and modern city life.

PHOTO / ASTANA BAYTEREK MONUMENT

THE EXPERIENCE

Astana is known for striking contemporary architecture and broad public spaces. Visit the Bayterek monument, admire the cityscape along Nurzhol Boulevard and explore major cultural institutions such as the National Museum. Its architectural contrasts make a rewarding introduction to modern Kazakhstan.

Expect wind and sharp temperature changes, especially outside summer.

PLACES & PERSPECTIVES

The architecture of Astana

Light, geometry and an ambitious skyline.

PHOTO / ASTANA KHAN SHATYR AND CITY / WIDE

PHOTO / ASTANA KHAN SHATYR AND CITY / DETAIL

PHOTO / ASTANA KHAN SHATYR AND CITY / ATMOSPHERE

THE ESSENTIAL GUIDE

Discover the north

Beyond the capital and into open landscapes.

INSIDER NOTES

Astana works well as a city break or a gateway to northern Kazakhstan. Travelers interested in nature can explore the Burabay resort region, known for pine forests, rock formations and lakes. Distances are substantial, so plan transfers carefully and allow enough time for an overnight stay when possible.

KEN DALA TIP

Northern winters can be severe; choose clothing and transport appropriate to the season.

PHOTO / CHARYN CANYON GOLDEN HOUR

The great outdoors

Canyons, forests and lakes of southeastern Kazakhstan.

Charyn Canyon

A landscape carved by time.

PHOTO / CHARYN CANYON VALLEY OF CASTLES

THE EXPERIENCE

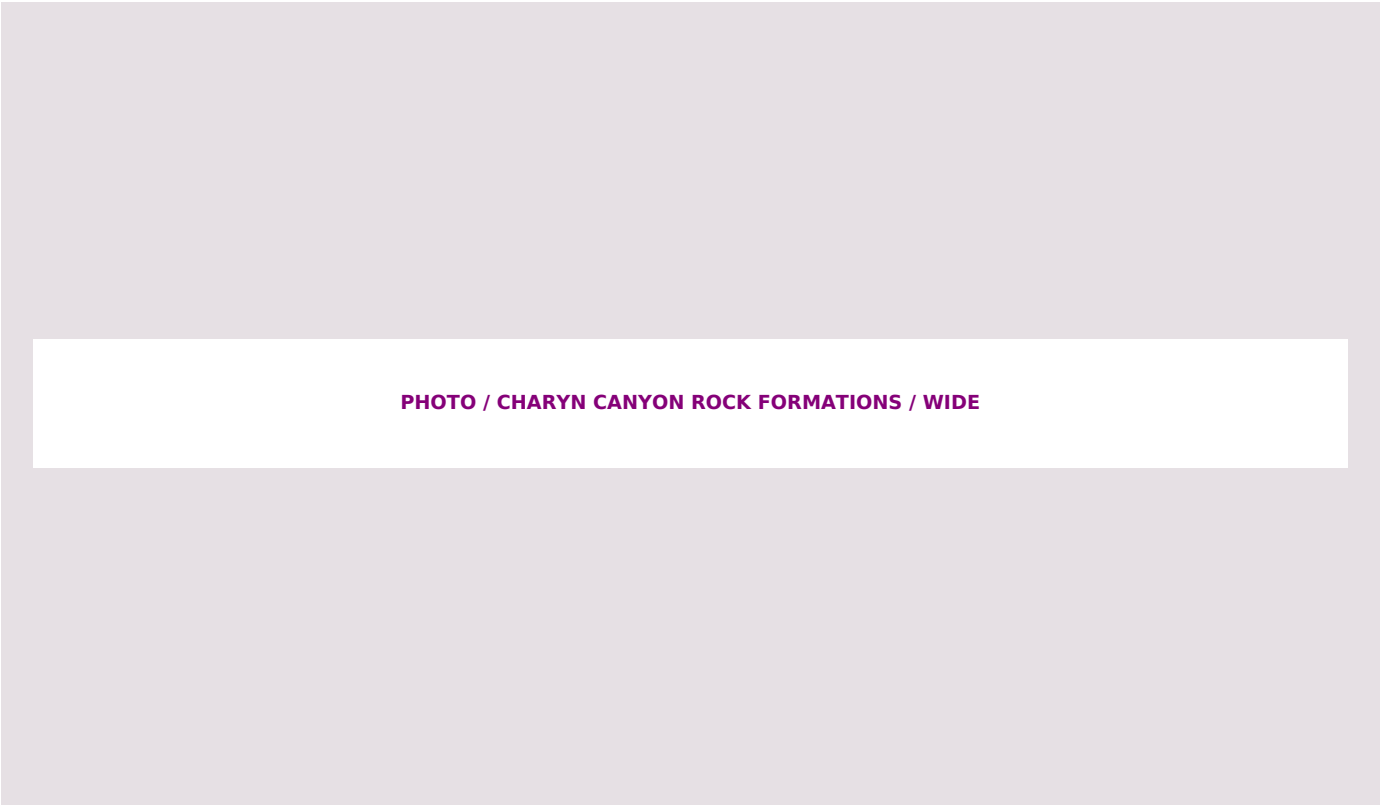
Charyn Canyon is celebrated for dramatic red and ochre rock formations. The Valley of Castles is among its best-known sections, offering striking viewpoints and a sense of immense scale. Guided visits from Almaty can be rewarding, but travel and walking conditions require planning.

Carry water and sun protection; exposed canyon terrain can be very hot.

PLACES & PERSPECTIVES

The colors of Charyn

Sculpted cliffs and changing desert light.





Kolsai Lakes

Forest paths and mountain reflections.

PHOTO / LOWER KOLSAI LAKE

THE EXPERIENCE

The Kolsai Lakes sit in the northern Tian Shan amid conifer forests and steep mountain slopes. Visitors can enjoy lakeside scenery, photography and seasonal hiking. Routes to higher lakes may be strenuous and depend on conditions; plan an overnight stay nearby for a more relaxed experience.

Check trail conditions and national park regulations before hiking.

Kaindy Lake

An extraordinary submerged forest.

PHOTO / KAINDY LAKE SUBMERGED TREES / WIDE

PHOTO / KAINDY LAKE SUBMERGED TREES / DETAIL

PHOTO / KAINDY LAKE SUBMERGED TREES / ATMOSPHERE

THE ESSENTIAL GUIDE

Choose your adventure

How to experience the Almaty region.

INSIDER NOTES

Charyn Canyon rewards lovers of dramatic geology and photography. Kolsai is ideal for mountain scenery and gentle lakeside time, while Kaindy is known for its submerged spruce trunks and distinctive atmosphere. A combined journey often needs two or more days and suitable transport, particularly on rough approach roads.

KEN DALA TIP

Travel times can be longer than expected; avoid overloading a single-day itinerary.

PHOTO / TURKISTAN KHOJA AHMED YASAWI MAUSOLEUM

The Silk Road

Centuries of history across southern Kazakhstan.

Turkistan

A spiritual and architectural landmark.

PHOTO / KHOJA AHMED YASAWI MAUSOLEUM

THE EXPERIENCE

Turkistan is home to the Mausoleum of Khoja Ahmed Yasawi, a UNESCO World Heritage Site and one of Central Asia’s most important monuments. Its monumental turquoise dome and Timurid-era architecture reflect the region’s cultural heritage. Explore the historic setting with time for context and reflection.

Dress respectfully at sacred sites and confirm visitor arrangements.

PLACES & PERSPECTIVES

Stories in the steppe

Ancient cities and Silk Road echoes.

PHOTO / OTRAR ARCHAEOLOGICAL SITE / WIDE

PHOTO / OTRAR ARCHAEOLOGICAL SITE / DETAIL

PHOTO / OTRAR ARCHAEOLOGICAL SITE / ATMOSPHERE

Beyond the familiar

Mangystau, Altai and faraway horizons.

PHOTO / MANGYSTAU BOZZHYRA LANDSCAPE

THE EXPERIENCE

Kazakhstan’s less-visited regions reveal a different kind of beauty. Mangystau features chalk formations, desert escarpments and remote landscapes, while East Kazakhstan and the Altai offer forests, rivers and mountains. These areas reward travelers with time, specialist guides and a flexible approach.

Remote trips require experienced operators, reliable vehicles and careful logistics.

THE KEN DALA EDIT

PHOTO / KAZAKH YURT AND STEPPE

The living culture

Traditions that connect past and present.

Craft & heritage

Felt, textiles and the art of making.

PHOTO / KAZAKH FELT AND TRADITIONAL CRAFTS

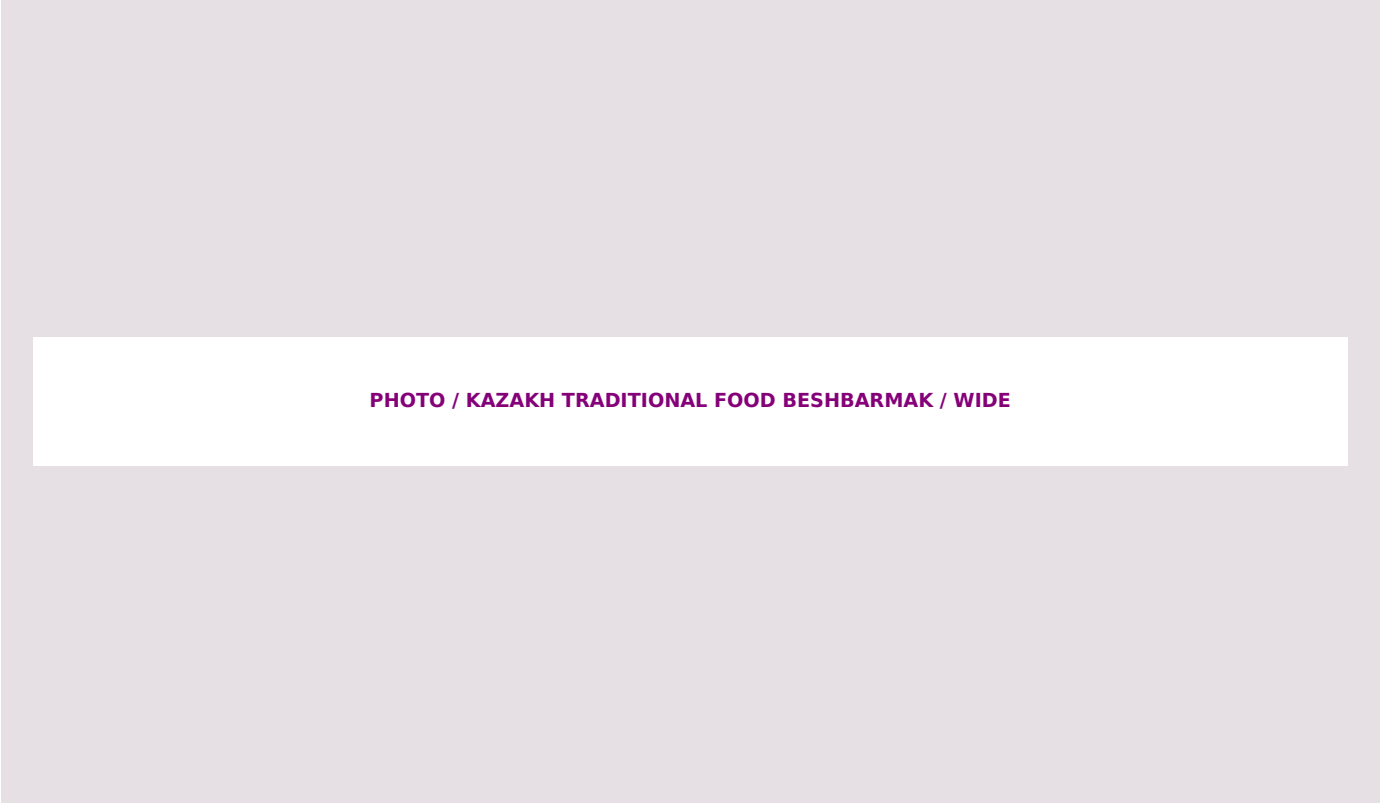
THE EXPERIENCE

Kazakh culture carries a rich heritage of feltwork, embroidery, jewelry, woodcraft and yurt-making. In museums, workshops and cultural centers, discover how patterns and materials express stories of family, identity and place. Seek authentic encounters with artisans and support local makers.

Ask permission before photographing people or private cultural gatherings.

The Kazakh table

Hospitality is part of the journey.



Flavors of Kazakhstan

Comforting dishes and generous hospitality.

PHOTO / KAZAKH BESHBARMAK BAURSAK TABLE

THE EXPERIENCE

Discover beshbarmak, a traditional dish of meat and noodles, alongside baursak, small pieces of fried dough, and regional specialties such as kuyrdak. Tea plays an important role in hospitality, and fermented dairy drinks are part of local food traditions. Modern restaurants offer creative interpretations alongside classic recipes.

Ask about ingredients and dietary needs; some traditional dishes are meat-heavy.

THE ESSENTIAL GUIDE

The little rituals

Language, etiquette and meaningful encounters.

INSIDER NOTES

Kazakh is the state language and Russian is also widely used. A friendly “Sälemetsiz be” is a polite Kazakh greeting; “Raqmet” means thank you. Respect household customs, follow guidance when visiting religious or cultural sites and accept hospitality graciously. Always ask before taking portraits.

KEN DALA TIP

A few local words and a genuine interest in traditions go a long way.

THE ESSENTIAL GUIDE

Before you fly

Documents, money and useful details.

INSIDER NOTES

Check Kazakhstan entry and visa requirements for your nationality through official government sources. The local currency is the tenge (KZT). Cards are common in major cities, while cash may be helpful in rural areas. Arrange suitable mobile connectivity, travel insurance and transfers; check current health, border and travel guidance before departure.

KEN DALA TIP

Entry rules, prices and access regulations change; reconfirm close to travel.

THE ESSENTIAL GUIDE

Move with ease

Distances, domestic flights and ground transport.

INSIDER NOTES

Kazakhstan is enormous. Domestic flights are often the most practical way to connect Almaty, Astana, Shymkent and western regions. Trains offer a slower way to experience the country, while private transfers or experienced guides help with remote attractions. Some mountain and desert roads require capable vehicles.

KEN DALA TIP

Allow generous connection time and do not assume remote roads are paved.

Three journey ideas

Sample routes to inspire your booking.

INSIDER NOTES

THE CLASSIC / 7–9 DAYS: Almaty + Charyn Canyon + Kolsai and Kaindy Lakes for city culture and alpine scenery. THE CITY & HERITAGE EDIT / 8–10 DAYS: Almaty + Astana + Turkistan for architecture, history and urban life. THE GRAND JOURNEY / 12–15 DAYS: Almaty region + Astana + Turkistan, with extra time for a specialist regional extension. These are illustrative ideas, not confirmed packages.

KEN DALA TIP

Ask Ken Dala to tailor the route to the season, interests and travel pace.

Travel with Ken Dala

Curated journeys shaped around you.

PHOTO / KAZAKHSTAN LUXURY MOUNTAIN LODGE

THE EXPERIENCE

Ken Dala offers a considered way to discover Kazakhstan, from distinctive city stays and mountain landscapes to heritage-rich destinations and cultural experiences. Whether you imagine sunrise at Charyn Canyon, a peaceful morning beside Kolsai Lake or an unforgettable encounter with Kazakh traditions, begin with the places that inspire you.

Contact Ken Dala through its official channels to discuss current tour options.

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PHOTO / KAZAKHSTAN MOUNTAIN SUNSET FINAL HERO

Your next story begins here

Kazakhstan is waiting. Discover it with Ken Dala.